STRENGTH FOR LIFE

COMMON MISTAKES GUIDE

Identify, Correct, and Master Form for Functional Power & Injury Prevention



Dr. Rosanne Woods, PhD

COMMON MISTAKES & FORM GUIDE

How to Train Smarter, Safer, and More Effectively

Introduction: The Foundation of Strength

Strength training stands as one of the most potent tools available for enhancing your overall health and longevity, offering benefits that range from increased bone density and muscle preservation to improved glucose control and metabolic function. However, the true value of your training isn't found just in the amount of weight you lift, but in how you perform each movement. The way you interact with resistance dictates which muscles are activated and how your joints absorb the load. Even small technical errors—such as improper foot placement or a rounded spine—can create a "leak" in your power output, significantly reducing the effectiveness of the exercise and slowing your overall progress.

Beyond just stalling your gains, poor mechanics can increase the risk of persistent discomfort or acute injury. When the body is out of alignment, stress is often diverted away from the target muscles and onto connective tissues that aren't designed to handle such force. It is important to remember, however, that good form is not about achieving unattainable perfection or looking like a textbook illustration. Instead, it is about developing consistency and control.

By focusing on a stable, repeatable movement pattern, you ensure that every repetition serves its intended purpose. True mastery comes from the ability to maintain your technique even as fatigue sets in, allowing you to train harder and longer while keeping your body resilient for decades to come.

Achieving Your Peak Potential: The Goals of This Guide

The primary objective of this guide is to provide you with a comprehensive roadmap for refining your strength training journey. By learning to recognize common mistakes, you can proactively identify the subtle errors in form or programming that often lead to plateaus or unnecessary injury. Awareness is the first step toward correction, ensuring that you aren't just working hard, but working correctly.

We are aiming to bridge the gap between effort and execution by helping you improve movement quality. Beyond simply lifting weights or hitting cardio targets, focusing on the mechanics of your body allows for better muscle recruitment and long-term joint health. As you master these fundamentals, you will naturally begin to train with more confidence, shedding the hesitation that comes with being unsure of your technique. This mental shift is crucial; when you trust your body's ability to perform, you can push through barriers that previously seemed insurmountable.

Ultimately, this guide is designed to ensure you get better results from each workout. We want to maximize the "return on investment" for every minute you spend training. By optimizing your approach and eliminating inefficiencies, you will see faster progress, more consistent gains, and a more sustainable path toward your personal health and performance goals.

The "Mistake-Proof" Manual: Mastering Your Mechanics

Progressive resistance training is one of the most proactive investments you can make in your healthspan, but "sloppy" reps are a wasted opportunity. Below are the most frequent errors I see in the gym and—more importantly—how to fix them instantly to ensure every rep is a deposit into your longevity bank.

1. The "Upper-Back Slouch" (Upper Body Pulls)

- **The Mistake:** During rows or lat pulldowns, many lifters initiate the pull by jutting their chin forward or "shrugging" their shoulders up toward their ears. This leads to neck tension and prevents the large back muscles (the lats) from doing the work.
- **The Fix: "Shoulders to Back Pockets."** Before you pull, imagine you are tucking your shoulder blades down and into your back pockets. Lead with your elbows, not your hands.

2. The "Valgus Collapse" (Squats & Step-Ups)

- **The Mistake:** As you squat or step up, your knees cave inward toward each other. This puts unnecessary rotational stress on the knee joint, ACL, and meniscus.
- **The Fix: "Screw Your Feet into the Floor."** Imagine you are trying to spread the floor apart between your feet. This creates external rotation at the hip, which automatically keeps your knees tracking safely over your second and third toes.

3. The "Butt Wink" & Over-Arching (Deadlifts & Pressing)

- **The Mistake:** Either rounding the lower back at the bottom of a deadlift or excessively arching the lower back during an overhead press. Both leave your lumbar spine vulnerable under load.
- **The Fix: "Ribs to Hips."** Think of your core as a 360-degree cylinder. Keep your ribs "knitted" down toward your hip bones. If you feel your lower back arching during an overhead press, squeeze your glutes firmly to lock your pelvis into a safe, neutral position.

4. Moving Too Slow on the "Up" (The Power Gap)

- **The Mistake:** Performing the entire exercise at a slow, leisurely pace. While eccentric control is essential, moving too slowly on the lifting (concentric) phase fails to recruit the vital Type II (fast-twitch) muscle fibers that decline fastest with age.
- **The Fix: "Slow Down, Snap Up."** Lower the weight with a controlled 2-to-3-second count, then drive the weight up with a crisp, **purposeful 1-count**. Move the weight with intent!

5. The "Ego Lift" vs. The "Empty Rep"

- **The Mistake:** Using weight so heavy that your form breaks down OR using weights so light that you could do 40 reps without breaking a sweat. Neither produces the mechanical tension required for adaptation.
- **The Fix: Target RPE 8.** You should finish your working set feeling like you could have done 2 more "perfect" reps, but definitely not 5. If your form gets sloppy, the weight is too heavy. If you aren't challenged by the final two reps, it's too light.

Dr. Rosanne's Pro-Tip:

*"Form isn't about looking 'pretty' in the gym. It's about **Force Distribution**. When your form is correct, the load goes into your muscles and bones (where we want it) and stays out of your spinal discs and tendons (where we don't)."*

Exercise-Specific Mastery: The "Feel, Fix, & Flow" Guide

Use this guide as you move through your weekly workouts. If an exercise feels "off," look here first to troubleshoot your mechanics.

1. The Goblet Squat (Workout A)

- **What it should feel like:** Your weight balanced across your mid-foot. Your quads and glutes should be doing the heavy lifting, while your core feels like a rigid brace holding your torso tall.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Tip-Toe Squat."** Allowing your heels to lift off the floor as you descend, which shifts excessive shear force into your knees.
- **How to fix your form:** Imagine your feet are glued to the floor. Focus on sitting your hips *back and down* between your heels. If ankle stiffness causes your heels to lift, elevate your heels slightly on small weight plates while you work on your ankle mobility.

2. The Romanian Deadlift (Workout A)

- **What it should feel like:** A deep stretching tension in your hamstrings (the back of your thighs) as you hinge back, followed by a powerful contraction of your glutes and hamstrings to stand tall.
- **The Common Mistake: "Fishing for the Floor."** Reaching the dumbbells toward your toes by rounding your lower back. This turns a posterior-chain exercise into a risky lower-back strain.
- **How to fix your form:** Keep the weights shaving the front of your thighs and shins the entire time. Your vertical depth toward the floor doesn't matter—your horizontal hip hinge backward does. Stop lowering the instant your hips stop moving backward.

3. The Weighted Step-Up (Workout B)

- **What it should feel like:** The working leg (the foot on the box or bench) should feel like a piston driving you up through your heel and mid-foot.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Springboard Effect."** Using your trailing foot on the floor to bounce or push off into the step.
- **How to fix your form:** Lean your torso slightly forward over the front knee and lift the toes of your bottom foot before pressing up. This forces the top leg to do 100% of the work. Control the descent for a full 3-second count!

4. The Overhead Shoulder Press (Workout B)

- **What it should feel like:** Strong work in the shoulders and upper arms while your spine remains tall and stacked. Your abdominals and glutes stay engaged to prevent leaning backward.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Lean Back."** Hyperextending your lower back to turn an overhead press into an incline chest press.
- **How to fix your form:** Squeeze your glutes firmly to anchor your pelvis and keep your lower ribs stacked over your hips. You can also use a staggered stance or **Half-Kneeling Press** (one knee on the floor) to protect your lower back.

5. The One-Arm Row (Workout A)

- **What it should feel like:** A strong contraction in your mid-back and lats at the top of the movement, with your shoulder blade gliding smoothly without shrugging toward your ear.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Lawn-Mower Pull."** Yanking the weight straight up into your armpit while twisting your torso open.
- **How to fix your form:** Pull the dumbbell in an arc toward your hip pocket, not your shoulder. Keep your shoulders and hips square to the floor like headlights.

6. The Dead Bug (Workout B)

- **What it should feel like:** Your lower back gently pressed ("imprinted") into the floor, creating deep stabilizing tension across your entire anterior core.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Arching Spine."** Letting your lower back arch off the mat as your arm and leg extend toward the floor.
- **How to fix your form:** Exhale fully as you extend, and only lower your heel as far as you can maintain full lower-back contact with the mat. Precision of the core brace matters far more than how close your foot gets to the floor.

7. The Push-Up (Workout A)

- **What it should feel like:** Coordinated tension across the chest, shoulders, triceps, and core. Your body moves as one solid plank from head to heels.
- **The Common Mistake: "Sagging Hips" or "Pike Neck."** Letting the lower back sag toward the floor or craning the chin forward to reach the ground first.

- **How to fix your form:** Brace your glutes and quads to keep your body in a straight line. If floor push-ups cause your hips to sag or shoulders to shrug, perform an **Incline Push-Up** (hands on a bench, box, or sturdy counter) so you can train through a full, strong range of motion.

8. The Farmer's Carry (Workout A)

- **What it should feel like:** Elevated heart rate, challenged grip strength, and tall, stacked posture—as if a cable is pulling the crown of your head toward the ceiling.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Side-to-Side Sway."** Letting the dumbbells bang against your thighs or slumping your shoulders forward.
- **How to fix your form:** Take controlled, heel-to-toe steps. Keep the weights slightly clear of your sides, pack your shoulders down and back, and breathe steadily behind a braced core.

9. The Lat Pulldown / Band Pulldown (Workout B)

- **What it should feel like:** A wide, strong contraction across your upper and mid-back as your shoulder blades draw down and together.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Lean & Swing."** Leaning backward past 45 degrees and using body momentum to swing the resistance down.
- **How to fix your form:** Sit or kneel tall with a slight, fixed torso angle. Drive your elbows down toward your ribs and pause briefly at the bottom of every rep.

10. The Sumo Squat (Workout C)

- **What it should feel like:** Strong recruitment of the inner thighs (adductors), glutes, and quads with an upright torso.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Knee Cave."** Letting the knees collapse inside the ankles because of the wide stance.
- **How to fix your form:** Turn your toes out roughly 30–45 degrees and actively press your knees outward so they track directly in line with your toes throughout the squat.

11. The Single-Leg Deadlift (Workout C)

- **What it should feel like:** Deep work in the standing leg's hamstring, glute, and foot/ankle stabilizers—a masterclass in balance and functional hip strength.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Hip Opening."** Letting the pelvis of the raised leg rotate open toward the wall, which removes tension from the standing glute.

- **How to fix your form:** Point the toes of your back foot straight down toward the floor. Imagine your hip bones are two headlights that must shine straight down at the ground throughout the entire hinge.

12. The Low-to-High Band Press / Chop (Workout C)

- **What it should feel like:** A smooth, diagonal transfer of force from your legs and hips through a braced core and out through your shoulders.
- **The Common Mistake: "Arm-Only Movement."** Standing flat-footed and yanking the band with only your arms and shoulders.
- **How to fix your form:** Pivot your back foot and rotate your hips and ribcage together as a unit—just like swinging a golf club or throwing a ball. Power originates in the hips and is channeled through the core.

13. The Face Pull (Workout C)

- **What it should feel like:** A focused muscular burn in your rear deltoids and upper back between your shoulder blades, counteracting rounded shoulder posture.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Chin Poke."** Jutting your head and neck forward to meet the band.
- **How to fix your form:** Keep your neck long and chin slightly tucked. Pull the center of the band toward your forehead while externally rotating your hands apart so you finish in a "double-bicep" posture.

14. The Bird-Dog (Workout C)

- **What it should feel like:** Rock-solid spinal stability and length—a straight line of tension from your extended fingertips to your opposite heel.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Sky Kick."** Kicking the back leg high toward the ceiling, which hyperextends the lower back and dumps core tension.
- **How to fix your form:** Reach *long*, not high. Imagine pushing your heel straight backward into a wall behind you while keeping your pelvis level enough to balance a cup of water on your lower back.

> ***"Consistency over Intensity. Precision over Ego."***
> Refer back to this guide during your first two weeks until these cues become second nature. When your nervous system and muscles speak the same language, strength and power follow naturally.

Dr. Rosanne's Final Form Rule:

"If you can't control the weight, you aren't ready for the weight. In Strength for Life, we build power on a foundation of precision. Master the 'Feel,' apply the 'Fix,' and the 'Flow' will follow."

Conclusion: Your Strength Is Your Future

Committing to progressive strength training as we age is far more than a fitness routine—it is a direct investment in your metabolic resilience, bone density, joint integrity, and lifelong independence. While it is completely natural to feel some hesitation when learning new movement patterns or picking up heavier dumbbells, remember that every accomplished lifter started as a beginner. The form cues and mechanical principles in this guide are not barriers; they are the exact tools that empower you to train safely, confidently, and effectively.

By prioritizing consistency and movement quality over ego, you are doing far more than building muscle: you are expanding your body's primary glucose sink, protecting your joints and spine, and building functional capacity that carries over into every decade of your life.

> ***"Strength training is the closest thing we have to a fountain of youth. It's never too late to start, and you are never too old to get stronger."***

Grab your weights, trust your preparation, and enjoy watching your body respond with greater strength, energy, and resilience. Your strongest chapter starts right now.